nothing, then I would think that our risks increase." He felt that he needed to act decisively.[24]

In the past, every time Kennedy was bullied, outmaneuvered, or defeated by Khrushchev in their personal meetings, as at Vienna in June 1960, he would strike back by asking Congress either to increase the defense budget or to call up reservists, or both. He was overcompensating at home for diplomatic defeats abroad, not only to warn Khrushchev but also to protect himself politically in his own country. He was strengthening the American military and sending threatening signals to his nemesis. But this time was different. Kennedy felt that he had to use force. His brother Robert Kennedy was even more radical. He proposed a staged attack on the American base at Guantánamo Bay or the sinking of an American ship to justify the invasion, urging the group to go for invasion even if that incurred the possibility of a general war. Robert urged the rest "just to get into it and get it over with and take our losses."[25]

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THE MEETING ENDED WITHOUT REACHING A DECISION. ROBERT Kennedy counted eleven participants in the discussion favoring a blockade and seven advocating a strike. The latter group actually included nine people, if one counted the president and Robert Kennedy himself. Still, there was no consensus and no recommendation to the president. Rusk would go back to the State Department to resume meetings with his staff there. McNamara went to the Pentagon, where he would spend the first night of the crisis. John Kennedy went to a dinner in honor of his departing "Russia hand" Charles Bohlen, who was leaving for an ambassadorial appointment in Paris. Kennedy tried to convince Bohlen not to go, as he valued the latter's expertise, but Bohlen believed that a reversal of course would only raise unwanted questions and speculation. Both men were determined to keep the unfolding Soviet crisis secret from the media as long as possible.[26]

What neither Kennedy nor his advisers knew or could imagine at the time was that Soviet ballistic missiles were already combat-ready. Nuclear warheads for two of Colonel Sidorov's launch sites had been delivered ten